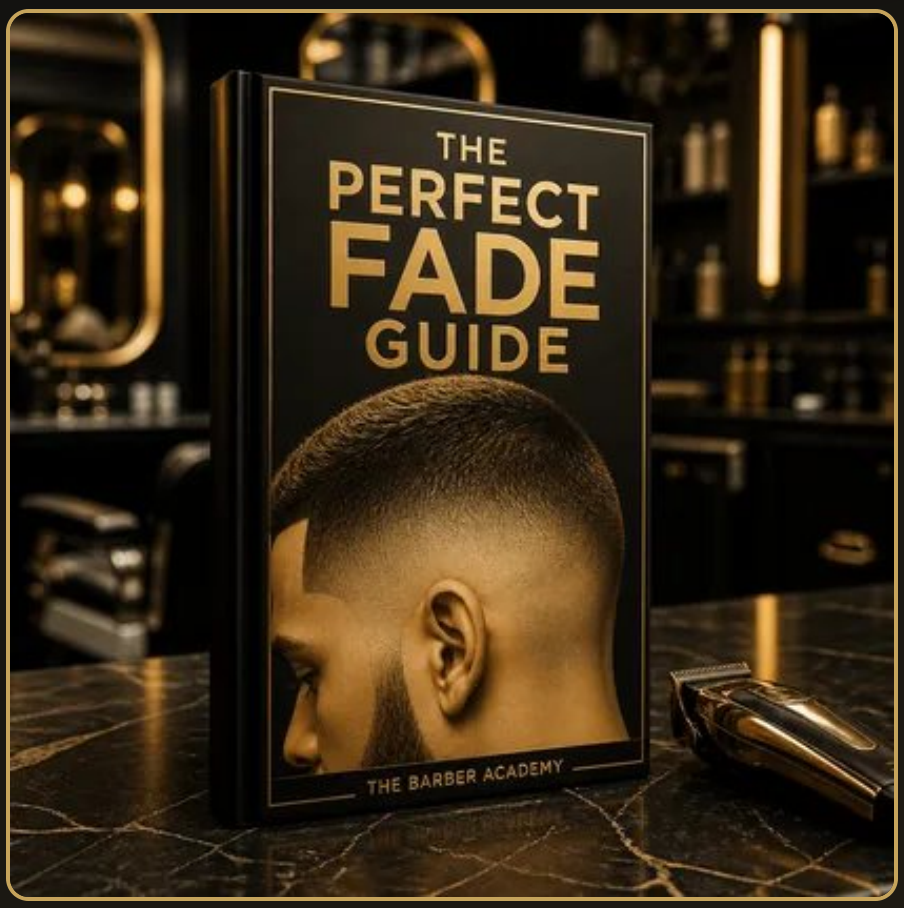
BONUS 1

The Perfect Fade Guide

Low, mid and high fades from the first pass to the last blend



In this guide

1. What a Fade Is

2. Anatomy of the Head

3. Tools and Guards

4. Setup and Sanitation

5. The Three Fade Tones

6. Skin Fade (Bald Fade) vs. Taper

7. Blending and Removing Lines

8. Detailing the Outline and Neckline

9. Fixing Patchiness

10. Adjusting for Hair Type

11. Your Four-Week Practice Plan

12. Final Checklist

Next Step

> *The fade is the haircut clients judge first and forgive last. It is a smooth gradient from short hair to longer hair, and there is nowhere to hide a mistake: every dark patch, every line, every uneven edge shows in the mirror. The good news is that a fade is a system, not a mystery. Once you understand the head, the tools, and the order of operations, you can repeat the same result on every client. This guide takes you from the anatomy of the head to a four-week practice plan, one step at a time.*

> **Safety and licensing first**
>
> Clippers, trimmers, and razors work very close to the skin. Disinfect every tool between clients, wash your hands before and after each service, wear gloves when the service calls for it, and use a fresh single-use blade for every razor service. In many places you need a barber or cosmetology license to charge for services. Check your local licensing requirements before working on paying clients. The Certificate of Completion that comes with this course is not a license.

1. What a Fade Is

A fade is a haircut in which the hair length changes gradually from very short at the bottom (near the neckline and sideburns) to longer at the top, with no visible line where one length ends and the next begins. The effect is created by blending several clipper lengths together, usually with a combination of guards, lever work, and a clipper-over-comb finish.

Three things decide how a fade looks: where it starts (how low or high the shortest area sits), how short it goes at the bottom (guard or bare skin), and how smooth the transition is. This guide treats each of those as a separate decision.

The parts of every fade

- **The shadow zone:** the shortest area at the bottom, where the hair is closest to the skin.
- **The transition zone:** the middle band where short blends into longer. This is where most of your skill shows.
- **The weight zone:** the area where the length returns to the full length of the top. It carries the visual weight of the cut.
- **The outline:** the clean edge around the hairline, temples, sideburns, and neckline.

2. Anatomy of the Head

Heads are not spheres. They have flat planes, curves, ridges, and dips, and your clippers will behave differently on each one. If you cut every area the same way, you will leave patches. Learn the landmarks first and the technique follows.

Landmarks you need to find on every client

- **Temple (frontal) area:** the soft corners of the forehead where the hairline meets the sideburn. The hair here is often fine and grows in odd directions.

- **Parietal ridge:** the point where the top of the head begins to curve down into the side. It is the natural widest point of the skull and usually the best place to set the top of a fade.
- **Occipital bone:** the bump at the back of the head. Clipper work must curve around it, not cut straight across it.
- **Crown:** the swirl at the back top of the head. Hair grows in a spiral here, so it needs extra care when blending.
- **Nape:** the lower back of the neck. Growth patterns here vary widely and determine how the neckline should be shaped.
- **Ears and sideburns:** the fade must wrap around these without nicking skin or leaving a bulge of hair.

Guidelines

A guideline is a visible line you create first, using a single guard length, to mark the top of your fade. Every later blend works up to that line and then dissolves it. There are two to know:

- **The fade guideline:** the top edge of the shortest zone. Its height decides whether the fade is low, mid, or high.
- **The weight line:** the natural shelf around the parietal ridge where the top hair stops hanging straight and begins to curve over.

> **Find the line before you cut it**
>
> Place your flat palm against the side of the head under the parietal ridge. The spot where your hand stops touching the skull is the weight line. Mark your guideline relative to it, a finger-width or two below for most fades. Clients with a very round or very flat head may need it adjusted.

Recession and temple areas

Many clients have a receding hairline at the temples. Do not try to hide it with a fade that sits perfectly straight; the eye will see the gap. Instead, follow the existing hairline, keep the temple area slightly longer when the hair is thin, and blend the sides into it. If you cut too short here, thin hair can look patchy and the recession looks worse. When in doubt, go one guard longer in the temple than on the rest of the side and refine later.

3. Tools and Guards

You do not need a huge toolbox for fades, but you do need to know what each tool is for and to keep them clean and sharp.

- **Full-size corded or cordless clipper:** the main tool for the bulk of the cut. Choose a model with an adjustable lever so you can open or close the blade gap.
- **Trimmer (T-blade type):** a small, narrow-bladed tool for outlines, edges, and detail work.
- **Foil shaver or small finisher:** for bald fades and for cleaning hair off the skin after the outline.
- **Set of attachment guards:** plastic combs that snap onto the clipper to set a length.

- **Fade brush:** a soft brush to sweep hair and keep your view clear, especially important in the blend.
- **Barber comb and flat top comb:** for clipper-over-comb work and for checking length.
- **Spray bottle, cape, neck strip, and towels:** for comfort and hygiene.
- **Straight or shavette razor with fresh blade:** for skin fades and fine lines, only where licensing allows.

Guard numbers and lengths

Guard numbers are measured in eighths of an inch, so a number 2 guard leaves hair at about 2/8 in (1/4 in). Guard systems vary slightly between manufacturers, so always test on a small area before committing. The table lists the standard ladder.

GUARD #	LENGTH (IN)	LENGTH (MM)	TYPICAL USE IN A FADE
Open blade, no guard	about 1/32	about 0.5-1	Shadow zone of a skin or very short fade
#0.5	1/16	1.5	Bottom of a low fade
#1	1/8	3	Bottom of most fades, first guideline in a low fade
#1.5	3/16	4.5	Lower transition
#2	1/4	6	Mid transition, bottom of a taper
#3	3/8	10	Upper transition
#4	1/2	13	Weight zone, upper blend
#5	5/8	16	Short top, weight zone
#6	3/4	19	Longer weight zone
#8	1	25	Maximum length before scissors take over

> **Test every guard first**
>
> Because systems differ, press each guard against your own forearm or a mannequin to compare the resulting length. Mark the sizes you own on a card so you always know the real number you are using.

Lever work

The lever on the side of many clippers opens or closes the blade gap. Closed means the blade is as short as it goes. Opened all the way leaves slightly longer hair. Using the lever between a guard length and the next one lets you create a gradient between two steps, which is how you get a truly seamless blend.

1. Set the lever fully closed and note the length.
2. Open it halfway and make a test pass on a mannequin. The hair should be a little longer.
3. Open it fully and compare. You now have three lengths from one guard.
4. Learn to flip the lever mid-stroke without stopping. Practice on a mannequin until it feels automatic.

Clipper over comb

Clipper over comb means holding a comb against the head, lifting the hair, and trimming what comes through the teeth with an open clipper. It is the finishing technique for blending where guards cannot reach, especially in the weight zone and above the ears. Keep the comb flat and angled slightly away from the head, move steadily upward, and let the clipper follow the comb without pushing into it.

- Hold the comb in your non-dominant hand and the clipper in your dominant hand.
- Keep the blade parallel to the comb at all times.
- Use short, controlled strokes and flick the clipper away from the head at the top of each pass to avoid a line.
- Always work from bottom to top.

4. Setup and Sanitation

A clean station is part of the service. It protects your client's skin and it protects your tools. Build a setup routine you follow every time, even when you are practicing on a friend.

Before the client sits down

1. Wash your hands with soap and water.
2. Disinfect the chair, counter, comb, and brush with an appropriate disinfectant, following its label for contact time.
3. Clean and disinfect clippers and trimmers, then oil the blades.
4. Install a fresh neck strip and a clean cape.
5. Open a fresh razor blade only if you will use one, and discard it into a sharps container afterward.
6. Lay out all the tools you will need so you never have to leave the client mid-cut.

During the service

- Keep your blades clean and oiled. Hair buildup causes pulling and uneven cutting.
- Check blade temperature on the back of your hand. A hot blade can burn skin.
- Brush off the client frequently so you can see the true length and avoid skin irritation.
- If you nick the skin, stop, put on gloves, apply gentle pressure with clean gauze, and use a product approved for minor cuts. Dispose of any contaminated materials safely.

After the service

1. Remove and discard used neck strips and razor blades properly.
2. Disinfect every tool that touched the client.
3. Sweep hair from the floor, bag it, and wash your hands again.
4. Wipe down the chair and station for the next client.

5. The Three Fade Tones

A fade is named for where it starts. Low, mid, and high fades all use the same blending logic. What changes is the height of the guideline and how much of the side is left in the shortest zone. Choose the tone based on face shape, head shape, hair density, and the client's lifestyle. Then follow the steps in order.

TONE	GUIDELINE HEIGHT	VISUAL EFFECT	BEST FOR
Low fade	Just above the ear and across the nape	Subtle, conservative, keeps more hair on the sides	Office settings, round heads, clients new to fades
Mid fade	About temple level, midway up the side	Balanced and modern, a clear gradient	Most clients, a safe default
High fade	At or above the temples, near the parietal ridge	Bold and sharp, high contrast	Clients who want a strong look, taller foreheads

The low fade: 10 steps

1. **Consult.** Confirm the length on top, the bottom guard, and whether the client wants a skin or shadow finish.
2. **Prepare.** Cape the client, dampen the hair lightly, and comb it in its natural direction.
3. **Mark the guideline.** Choose a guard (often #1 or #1.5) and cut a line about one inch above the top of the ear, curving down toward the nape.
4. **Cut the bottom.** Using the guard, work from the neckline up to the guideline, in short upward strokes.
5. **Drop one guard.** Take the next guard up and work from the guideline upward about one inch.
6. **Use the lever.** Open the lever slightly and flick out at the top of each stroke to soften the guideline.
7. **Clipper over comb.** Move above the transition and blend the weight zone into the top length.
8. **Check the back.** Go around the occipital bone and the crown, keeping the clipper parallel to the skull.
9. **Outline.** Use a trimmer to shape the sideburns, ears, and neckline.
10. **Final check.** Brush the client, comb through, look from every angle, and fix any patch or line.

Common mistakes in a low fade

- Setting the guideline too high, which turns a low fade into a mid fade.
- Cutting straight across the nape instead of following the natural curve of the neck.
- Taking too much off at the sideburn, which can make the face look longer.
- Rushing the blend near the ear, leaving a heavy patch above it.

The mid fade: 10 steps

1. **Consult.** Confirm the bottom length (guard or skin) and how long the hair stays on top.
2. **Prepare.** Cape, dampen, and comb. Feel the head for the parietal ridge.

3. **Mark the guideline.** Start about at temple height, level with the outer corner of the eyebrow, and keep the line straight and even all the way around.
4. **Cut the bottom.** Use the shortest guard or open blade to cut from the neck up to the guideline.
5. **First transition.** Move up one guard and blend from the guideline to roughly a finger-width above it.
6. **Second transition.** Move up another guard and repeat. Overlap each section by half an inch to avoid lines.
7. **Lever work.** Go back through every transition, opening and closing the lever to soften any hint of a line.
8. **Clipper over comb.** Blend the top of the side into the weight zone, working around the parietal ridge.
9. **Back and crown.** Repeat on the back, matching the height of the side guideline exactly.
10. **Outline and check.** Detail the hairline, brush the client, and inspect from every angle.

Common mistakes in a mid fade

- Uneven guideline height from one side to the other. Check with a comb held level against both ears.
- Skipping guard steps, which creates harsh bands instead of a smooth gradient.
- Pressing the clipper into the skin on the curve of the skull, which leaves dark scoops.
- Not matching the back to the sides.

The high fade: 10 steps

1. **Consult.** A high fade is a strong look. Confirm the client wants the bulk of the side very short.
2. **Prepare.** Cape, dampen, and comb. Locate the parietal ridge.
3. **Mark the guideline.** Place the line at or just under the parietal ridge, higher than the temple on most clients.
4. **Cut the bottom.** Use a very short setting from the neck up to the guideline. This is a large area, so keep the strokes even.
5. **Close the shadow.** Work in smaller sections near the ears, where it is easy to leave stray long hairs.
6. **First transition.** Move up one guard and blend about half an inch to an inch up from the guideline.
7. **Second transition.** Move up again and blend the next section. High fades usually need less vertical space for the blend, so work tightly.
8. **Lever and flick.** Use the lever and wrist flick on every pass to dissolve the guideline completely.
9. **Clipper over comb.** Blend into the top, paying close attention to the temples and crown.
10. **Outline and check.** A high fade shows every irregularity. Check from the front, side, and back under good light.

Common mistakes in a high fade

- Choosing a high fade for a client whose head shape or hairline will not support it.
- Taking the guideline above the parietal ridge, which exposes the curve of the skull.
- Spending too little time on the temples, where a high fade is most visible.

- Leaving the gap between short and long too abrupt.

> **Fade tones are a conversation, not a guess**
>
> Show the client a reference photo or point out the height on their own head before you start. Placing a finger or comb at the intended guideline eliminates most misunderstandings.

6. Skin Fade (Bald Fade) vs. Taper

The skin fade, sometimes called a bald fade, takes the bottom of the cut all the way down to bare skin. A taper keeps some hair at the bottom and gently follows the hairline. Both are blends, but they look and feel very different.

FEATURE	SKIN / BALD FADE	TAPER
Bottom length	Bare skin or foil-shaved	Short hair, usually #1 or #2
Contrast	High and dramatic	Soft and gradual
Where it sits	Any height: low, mid, or high	Mostly sideburns and neckline
Maintenance	Needs a refresh every 1 to 2 weeks	Holds up 3 to 4 weeks
Skill demand	Very high; no hair to hide mistakes	Moderate; more forgiving
Skin concerns	Razor bumps, ingrown hairs, irritation	Fewer concerns

How to take it to skin

1. Complete the fade using the shortest clipper setting first, so only a small amount of hair remains.
2. Switch to a foil shaver or a trimmer with the blade slightly exposed.
3. Work with light pressure and short strokes against the grain only if the client's skin tolerates it.
4. Where licensing permits and the client's skin is not sensitive, a fresh razor with shave gel can add a polished finish.
5. Finish with a cool towel and a soothing, alcohol-free aftercare product.

> **Skin care matters**
>
> Do not run a razor or a foil shaver repeatedly over the same spot. Check for moles, scars, bumps, or irritated areas first, and avoid them. If the client has a skin condition, ask them to consult a medical professional before a close shave.

7. Blending and Removing Lines

Lines are the number one fade problem. A line appears wherever one length stops too suddenly. You remove it by overlapping lengths and tapering the clipper away from the head at the end of each stroke.

The flick

Flicking is a small outward and upward wrist motion at the end of a clipper stroke. The blade leaves the hair gradually instead of stopping dead, which feathers the edge of each section.

1. Place the clipper at the bottom of the section, with the guard flat on the head.
2. Move upward with steady speed along the contour of the skull.
3. As you reach the top of the stroke, rotate your wrist outward and lift the clipper away.
4. Repeat with slight overlap, moving around the head in a consistent pattern.

Fixing a line

- **Dark line:** a band of longer hair. Use the next lowest guard or a closed lever to blend it down, then flick out.
- **Light line:** a band that is too short. Blend upward with a longer guard to soften what sits above it.
- **Stubborn line:** use clipper over comb. The comb lifts hair evenly, so the clipper cuts it consistently.

Blend checklist while cutting

- Look at the head from several angles, not only the mirror in front of you.
- Squint or step back; lines are easier to see from a distance.
- Run your fingers against the grain; uneven length is often easier to feel than see.
- Use good lighting. Overhead light hides lines; a light from the side reveals them.

8. Detailing the Outline and Neckline

The outline frames the fade. A clean frame can rescue an average blend, and a messy one can ruin a perfect blend. Detailing is done with a trimmer, and sometimes a razor, after the blend is complete.

The front hairline and temples

1. Hold the trimmer with the blade teeth facing out and start at the center of the forehead.
2. Follow the natural hairline. Do not move it unless the client requests it.
3. Shape the temple corners to match each other, using a comb as a measure.
4. Keep your wrist light, drawing short strokes rather than long sweeps.

Sideburns and ears

- Set the sideburn length with the client looking straight ahead.
- Keep both sides at the same height. Check by comparing against the ear and the corner of the eye.
- Fold the ear forward gently and trim around it with the trimmer blade pointed away from the skin.
- Use your free hand to hold the skin taut for a clean edge.

Neckline shapes

SHAPE	DESCRIPTION	GOOD FOR
Rounded	A soft curve that follows the neck	Most clients; grows out evenly
Squared	A flat bottom with sharp corners	Short fades, strong jaw lines
Tapered	Fades down to nothing along the nape	Natural look, quick grow-out
Blocked	A hard line at the base	Neat finishes; shows growth quickly

Pick a neckline that suits the client's nape growth. A tapered neckline is the most forgiving if the client does not visit often.

9. Fixing Patchiness

Even experienced barbers leave the occasional patch. The key is to diagnose what went wrong and correct it without making it worse. Here are the most common problems and their fixes.

PROBLEM	LIKELY CAUSE	FIX
Dark band in the transition	Skipped a guard or stroke too short	Use the next lower guard with lever closed, then flick out
Light band or hole	Clipper pressed too hard or guard too short	Blend the area above it with a longer guard to hide the gap
Uneven sides	Different guideline heights	Compare both ears; match the higher side to the lower one
Stray long hairs	Missed hair in the shadow zone	Comb the area, then re-cut with the trimmer or clipper
Scooped look at the occipital bone	Cutting across instead of around	Adjust the angle to follow the curve of the skull
Patchy crown	Growth swirl cut against the pattern	Cut in the direction of the swirl and use clipper over comb
Heavy ears	Hair not cleared around the ear	Fold the ear forward and re-blend with a smaller guard
Choppy top	Weight zone not blended	Use clipper over comb and scissors to soften

> **When in doubt, go up a guard**
>
> It is always easier to take more hair off than to put it back. If you are not sure how to fix a patch, raise the guard one number, blend the surrounding area, and reassess. A slightly longer fade with a clean blend looks better than a short fade with a hole in it.

10. Adjusting for Hair Type

Hair type changes how a fade looks and how it should be cut. Straight, wavy, curly, and coily hair each hold length and show lines differently. Adapt your technique to the hair, not the other way around.

Straight hair

- Lies flat and shows lines easily.
- Wet the hair lightly to keep it controlled, but check dry before finishing.
- Clipper over comb works well and is usually quick.
- Blend slowly; any step in length shows.

Wavy hair

- Waves can hide or reveal blending depending on direction.
- Cut the hair slightly damp so you can see its natural pattern.
- Leave a little extra length in the weight zone, because wavy hair springs up when it dries.
- Use lever work to soften the gradient.

Curly hair

- Curls spring back after cutting, so the finished length is shorter than it looked when stretched.
- Cut dry or lightly damp, using a comb to lift the curls evenly.
- Use a slightly longer guard than for straight hair to reach the same visual length.
- Blend with a brush and comb to avoid tufts at the transition.

Coily hair

- Very dense and tightly coiled, which makes lines look sharper and blending more important.
- Cut dry for the most accurate length reading.
- Move the clipper slowly and keep the blades clean, since coiled hair clogs them quickly.
- Skin fades and sharp outlines are popular; take extra care with razor work, because ingrown hairs are more likely.
- Moisturize the scalp after the service to reduce dryness and irritation.

HAIR TYPE	CUT CONDITION	GUARD ADJUSTMENT	WATCH FOR
Straight	Damp or dry	Standard guard	Visible lines
Wavy	Slightly damp	Standard or one longer	Spring when dry
Curly	Dry or slightly damp	One longer than usual	Tufts at transitions
Coily	Dry	Standard or one longer	Ingrown hairs, clogged blades

11. Your Four-Week Practice Plan

Skill comes from repetition in a safe setting. A practice mannequin head with real or synthetic hair is the best way to build speed and accuracy without risk. Work through the plan below, spending about 30 to 45 minutes per session, three or four sessions each week.

Week 1: Control

1. Drill 1: Make straight upward strokes with the clipper on a mannequin at one guard length, focusing on constant speed.
2. Drill 2: Practice flicking out at the end of each stroke on a single guard.
3. Drill 3: Cut a guideline at one height around the whole head and compare both sides.
4. Drill 4: Practice the lever, starting closed and opening gradually on a patch of hair.

Week 2: Blending

1. Drill 1: Cut a two-guard blend (for example #1 to #2) and make the line disappear.
2. Drill 2: Add a third guard and repeat.
3. Drill 3: Use lever work alone to blend between two guards.
4. Drill 4: Practice clipper over comb on the upper part of the side.

Week 3: Full fades

1. Drill 1: Complete a full low fade, timed, following the 10 steps.
2. Drill 2: Complete a mid fade and compare it with the low one.
3. Drill 3: Complete a high fade and check how the guideline sits on the parietal ridge.
4. Drill 4: Photograph each result from the front, side, and back, and note any flaws.

Week 4: Refinement

1. Drill 1: Practice outlines and necklines with the trimmer until both sides are symmetrical.
2. Drill 2: Take one fade down to a skin finish on a mannequin using a foil shaver.
3. Drill 3: Fix deliberate mistakes: cut a patch, then blend it out.
4. Drill 4: Complete three fades back to back with the full setup and cleanup routine.

> **Move to a real head only when you are ready**
>
> When your mannequin work is consistent, practice on a willing friend or family member under supervision, and follow your local rules about practicing and licensing. Start with a longer, forgiving fade like a low taper before attempting skin fades.

How to track your progress

- Take photos after each practice session from the same three angles.
- Write down your time for each fade and watch it fall as your confidence grows.
- Keep a list of recurring mistakes and focus on one at a time.
- Watch the video lessons in the Fades module of this course and compare your technique with theirs.

12. Final Checklist

BEFORE THE CLIENT LEAVES THE CHAIR

☐ Both sides are the same height and the guideline is invisible.

☐ No dark bands or light patches in the transition.

☐ The weight zone blends into the top with no shelf.

☐ The back and crown match the sides.

☐ The outline, sideburns, and neckline are clean and symmetrical.

☐ Stray hairs on the neck, ears, and forehead have been removed.

☐ The skin is free of nicks, redness, and loose hair.

☐ The client has seen the cut from the back and approved it.

☐ Tools are cleaned, disinfected, and put away.

☐ The client knows how long to wait before the next visit.

BEFORE EACH PRACTICE SESSION

☐ Clippers are clean, oiled, and charged or plugged in.

☐ All guards are accounted for and labeled.

☐ Mannequin is secured and at the right height.

☐ Brush, comb, spray bottle, and trimmer are within reach.

☐ A phone or camera is ready to photograph the result.

☐ You have picked one skill to focus on for the day.

Next Step

Open the Fades module in your course and follow the video lessons for the low, mid, and high fade in order, pausing to repeat each step on your mannequin. Then move on to the Professional Beard Manual to learn how to blend a beard into a fade for a complete finished look.